

Music and Emotion Experiment Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • The Arts • 20-30 min

Category	The Arts	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	music-and-emotion-experiment

Big idea: Form shapes perception and feeling.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: The same image or scene paired with different soundtracks. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Emotion rating cards before and after the music changes. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Music and Emotion Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A discussion of whether emotion reveals knowledge or distorts it. Describe what you see or hear first, then add title/context and revise the interpretation.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Form shapes perception and feeling.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Music and Emotion Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can emotion be a source of knowledge?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- The same image or scene paired with different soundtracks.
- Emotion rating cards before and after the music changes.
- A discussion of whether emotion reveals knowledge or distorts it.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to The Arts.

Activity Steps

1. Play the silent clip with Soundtrack A. Students write what they think is happening.
2. Repeat with Soundtracks B and C.
3. Students compare changes in perceived story, character and mood.
4. Discuss whether music reveals or manipulates meaning.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can emotion be a source of knowledge?
- Does art manipulate or reveal?
- How does form affect meaning?

Knowledge Questions

- Can emotion be a source of knowledge?
- Does art manipulate or reveal?
- How does form affect meaning?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with the same image or scene paired with different soundtracks. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...